“puzzled” by Kissinger’s implication that if China intervened in an India-Pakistan conflict, Delhi would “have to rely on” Moscow.[169]

Sino-US rapprochement, made public on July 15, in and of itself did not make an India-Soviet treaty inevitable. As a US intelligence assessment noted, the senior Indian leadership believed that “cautious steps” to improve US-China relations per se were to the “net advantage” of India.[170] Gandhi indeed welcomed the beginning of Sino-American normalization.[171] Rather, the treaty was the result of a confluence of conditions: the Bangladesh crisis, Gandhi’s expanded domestic political capacity, the Indian need for deterrence, and the Soviet desire for a treaty in return for providing that deterrence, as well as the lack of an available US option to diversify that deterrence given the Sino-US rapprochement.

The impact of the rapprochement on the role of the US in the crisis was of particular concern. At the onset of the Bangladesh crisis, an influential defense expert had assessed the “probability of Chinese intervention” as “low.” Even if Beijing intervened, he asserted “the chances of Super Power support to India appear to be fairly high in the current circumstances.”[172] But the altered Sino-US dynamic suggested American support against China might not be forthcoming. At a meeting on July 17, Kissinger’s indication to Jha that India would be on its own if it took action in East Pakistan and China intervened caused further concern.[173] Haksar worried that American officials “might act in the same manner as they did in 1965,” which, in the Indian view, had involved the US sitting back.[174] These developments occurred when there was a real chance of an India-Pakistan war, with the possibility of Chinese intervention.

Indian officials worried that the Sino-US rapprochement, particularly Islamabad’s role, might indeed have made the Bangladesh crisis worse. It further strengthened Pakastani intransigence, D. P. Dhar told Gromyko in August.[175] Briefing Gandhi before she was scheduled to meet Gromyko, Haksar laid out a picture of the possibility of Yahya going to war “egged on by China, and general support of the United States.” Perhaps to egg the Soviets on to support India, he also asserted that China’s motive was “the economic and political disruption of India without firing a shot.” There had already been reports of Chinese troop movements in Gilgit.[176] Thus, for Delhi, the Indo-Soviet treaty was now more desirable to India than before—